

Claims & Argument Structure

Study Guide - Arguments & Sources

1. Learning goal

Identify an author's main claim, distinguish supporting claims from evidence, and trace how the parts of an argument build toward a conclusion.

2. What this skill means

An argument is more than a topic or opinion. The main claim is the position the writer wants the reader to accept. Supporting claims give reasons for that position, and evidence gives facts, examples, or data that support those reasons. Reading the argument as a chain helps you see what each sentence is doing.

3. Do not confuse it with

Do not confuse a claim with evidence. "The city should add shade at the busiest stops" is a claim. "Ridership at those stops is highest between 2:00 and 5:00 p.m." is evidence. Also do not choose a broad topic such as "bus stops" when the question asks for the writer's actual position.

4. How GED-style questions may ask it

Questions may ask: "What is the author's main claim?", "Which statement is a supporting claim?", "What role does this detail play?", or "How does the author develop the argument?"

5. Repeatable method

- State the issue in a few words.
- Find the sentence or idea the writer most wants you to accept.
- Group the reasons underneath that claim.
- Label facts, examples, and data as evidence rather than claims.
- Check that your answer describes the whole argument, not one paragraph.

6. Worked example

A college proposes keeping the library open one hour later during exam weeks. A student survey found that 64 percent of respondents had difficulty finding quiet study space after 8 p.m. The proposal recommends a four-week pilot before any permanent schedule change.

Question: Which statement best expresses the main claim?

Reasoning: The survey is evidence and the four-week pilot is a detail about implementation. The central position is that the college should test later library hours during exam weeks.

Best answer: The college should test extending library hours during exam weeks.

7. Common traps

- Choosing the topic instead of the claim.
- Treating a statistic or example as if it were the writer's position.
- Choosing a supporting reason that is narrower than the whole argument.

8. Diagnostic help

- If you chose a number or factual detail, ask whether it is evidence rather than a claim.
- If your answer covers only one paragraph, zoom out and ask what the entire passage is trying to establish.
- If two claims seem possible, look for the one the other claims support.

9. Quick check

A manager argues that a six-week flexible-start pilot should continue because late arrivals fell and customer coverage remained stable.

What is the main claim?

Check yourself: The six-week flexible-start pilot should continue; the attendance and coverage results are supporting evidence.